Akriti: the physical structure common to a natural kind (***jati***) of entities. It manifests the generic property shared by them. *Samsthana* has the same meaning.

Alambana (objective ground): according to direct realists, the objective ground of a thought is whatever in the world it is about. An objective ground is both the extra-mental cause and the representative content of an idea. A hallucination is not an objectively grounded thought: it has content but it is caused by some defect in the perceptual system. Similarly, a rainbow is not caused by bands of colour but by light reflected in drops of moisture.

In his *Alambana-pariksha*, the Buddhist ***Dignaga*** tries to refute the atomic theory of the ***Abhidharma*** Buddhists by calling into question this notion of objective grounding. They think that we directly perceive structured masses of real atoms of various kinds. ***Dignaga*** questions the possibility of atomic aggregation. But even granting that collections of atoms may cause mental representations, they do not figure in the subjective content of awareness. A compound of clay atoms may cause the perception of a pot, but we do not see a cluster of atoms. What we have is an experience of a solid, coloured, extended object. ***Dignaga*** concludes that only an idea (a mental image that appears as if external) can be the support of another idea. It may be both instrumental in bringing about the idea and match its representational content.

Further reading: Ganeri 2001a; Matilal 1986

Alata-cakra (whirling firebrand): symbol used by Buddhists to illustrate the way in which consecutive similar elements of existence, although existing only for a moment, succeed each other with such inconceivable rapidity that illusions of substantial continuity are generated. This raises the